

FREE PORT GUIDE · PORT OF CALL

Oranjestad, Aruba
Your Margaritaville at Sea day ashore

One Happy Island: sunshine nearly every day, cooling trade winds, powder-white beaches and a colorful Dutch-Caribbean capital right at the pier.

SHIPS THAT CALL HERE
Beachcomber and Islander on select Southern Caribbean sailings (2027 and later)

WHERE YOU DOCK
Oranjestad cruise port, on the edge of downtown (your daily Cruise News lists the pier)

WALK TO TOWN
About 5–10 minutes to the waterfront boulevard and shopping streets

MONEY
Aruban florin; U.S. dollars are accepted everywhere

ISLAND TIME
Atlantic time, no daylight saving. Always go by ship time

ID AND LANGUAGE
Bring your passport. Locals speak Papiamento and Dutch, and English is everywhere

🛳️ Stepping off the ship

At the pier

- The port sits right at the edge of downtown, so you can **walk off the ship and into town**.
- Shops, cafés and the marina are along the waterfront boulevard. The main shopping streets are a few blocks in.
- **Booked a tour?** Check your voucher for the meeting spot near the terminal.

Getting around

- **Taxis** wait near the port. There are no meters: fares are **set by the government** and priced per car for up to 4 people. From downtown, Eagle Beach runs about $16 and Palm Beach about $22. Confirm before you ride.
- **Arubus** public buses run to the beaches and are cheap, but allow extra time.
- Jeeps and UTVs are popular for the rugged north coast. Go with a guided tour if you're short on time.

⏰ **The golden rule:** be back at the pier **at least 30–60 minutes before all-aboard**. Island traffic can slow down a beach taxi ride, and the ship will not wait.

🌴 Pick your perfect Aruba day

🏖️ Eagle Beach

About 10 min by taxi

A wide, soft, uncrowded stretch of white sand with calm turquoise water. Snap a photo with the famous twisted fofoti trees, then rent a palapa and an umbrella and just relax.

🍹 Palm Beach

About 15–20 min by taxi

Aruba's lively resort strip has beach bars, water sports, piers and people-watching. Hop on a banana boat, parasail, or find a beachfront bar for a cold Balashi.

🛍️ Downtown Oranjestad

Walk from the pier

Stroll past pastel Dutch-colonial buildings, shop the main streets, and visit Fort Zoutman, the island's oldest building, with its landmark clock tower. It's an easy, no-plan day.

🐠 Snorkel and shipwrecks

Half day by boat

Catamaran trips visit calm coves and the huge Antilla wreck, one of the largest in the Caribbean. The water is clear and calm on the west side, which makes it great for first-time snorkelers.

🌵 The wild side: Arikok and the north coast

Half day by jeep tour

Cactus-covered hills, caves, crashing waves and the hidden Natural Pool. It's best done on a guided jeep or UTV tour, because the roads are rough. Then stop at the California Lighthouse for sweeping views.

🐚 Baby Beach

About 30–40 min by taxi

At the island's far southern tip, this shallow, sheltered lagoon is like a giant swimming pool. It's worth the ride if your ship is in port all day. Agree on a return pickup time with your driver.

🍽️ Local flavors to try

- **Pastechi:** flaky fried pastries stuffed with cheese, meat or fish, the perfect beach snack.
- **Keshi yena:** a ball of cheese baked with savory spiced meat.
- **Fresh catch of the day** with funchi (cornmeal) and fried plantains.
- **Balashi beer,** brewed right on the island.
- **An Aruba Ariba,** the island's signature fruity rum cocktail. 🍹
- **Tap water is safe** here. Aruba makes its own from the sea, so refill your bottle.

💵 Money, shopping and tipping

- **U.S. dollars work everywhere;** change may come back in florins. Cards are widely accepted.
- Bring small bills for taxis, beach chairs and tips.
- Many restaurants add a service charge, so check the bill before tipping extra.
- Popular take-homes: aloe products (grown on the island), local art and Dutch cheese.

☀️ Weather and staying safe

Aruba is hot, sunny and breezy all year, with highs in the upper 80s °F and very little rain. It sits south of the usual hurricane path, but storms can still affect the sea.

👉 **Check the forecast before you go: Oranjestad 10-day forecast on weather.com** (or scan the code).

Sun and wind

- The **breeze hides how strong the sun is**. Reapply sunscreen often and wear a hat.
- Pack **reef-safe, mineral sunscreen** for snorkeling, and never touch the coral.
- On the north coast the surf is rough, so admire it but don't swim.

Smart cruiser habits

- Use licensed taxis and confirm the fare before you go.
- Watch your bags on busy beaches, and don't leave valuables in rental jeeps.
- Bring your passport ashore, or a copy if your ship advises keeping it on board.

🎒 Your Aruba day bag

- [ ] Ship card (room key) and passport
- [ ] Small U.S. bills for taxis and tips
- [ ] Reef-safe sunscreen, hat and sunglasses
- [ ] Swimsuit and cover-up
- [ ] Hair tie or clip, because it's windy!
- [ ] Refillable water bottle
- [ ] Phone set to **ship time**, with an alarm
- [ ] Ship's port agent number from your Cruise News
- [ ] Waterproof phone pouch
- [ ] Snorkel mask (optional)

Want the best of Aruba without the guesswork?

Our travel advisors can line up beach days, catamaran snorkels and jeep adventures that fit your ship's time in port.

📲 **Scan the code** to browse and book Aruba shore excursions.

Questions? **admin@thechillcompass.com**

Information current as of October 2026, gathered from Aruba's official tourism and taxi sources and cruise travel sources. Piers, times, prices and fares change, so please confirm with your ship's daily Cruise News before heading out. Travel times are approximate. Excursions are booked through Shore Excursions Group, and we may earn a commission at no extra cost to you. The Chill Compass is an independent blog and is not affiliated with, endorsed by or sponsored by Margaritaville at Sea or Margaritaville Enterprises. All trademarks belong to their respective owners. Presented by Cruises Tours and Travel, LLC · Florida Seller of Travel Reg. No. ST150140.